LIGHTING A POLITICAL TINDERBOX



BANDEEP SINGH

"We all think alike (that the tomb must be demolished), but some things must be done legally as it is a protected structure. It was made a protected structure by the former Congress regime"

DEVENDRA FADNAVIS
Chief Minister, Maharashtra

"We didn't keep asking each other when the Babri Masjid was demolished, our kar sevaks just did it...this is the time for a repeat. *Samajhdaar ko ishara kaafi hai* (For the smart, a signal is enough)"



NITESH RANE
Minister for Ports and Fisheries, Maharashtra

The success of a film is measured not only by its box-office earnings, but also by the emotions it can rouse in its audiences. *Chhaava* (meaning 'lion cub'), based on a popular Marathi novel on the 17th-century figure of Sambhaji, son of the iconic founder of the Maratha empire, Chhatrapati Shivaji, delivered on both scores. It had already raked in upwards of Rs 541 crore by the sixth week of its February 14 release. But what really propelled the drama to the headlines was an extended and graphic sequence of Mughal emperor Aurangzeb (played by Akshaye Khanna) torturing and killing Sambhaji (Vicky Kaushal) in 1689. The scenes had people breaking down in tears and shouting patriotic slogans in theatres—dutifully recorded on videos and circulated widely on social media. Its stature was confirmed when, amid cheers for Sambhaji and Shivaji, a special screening was held on March 27, at the GMC Balayogi auditorium in Parliament, where the audience included Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union home minister Amit Shah, BJP president J.P. Nadda and their NDA colleagues.

The plot had already moved off-stage before that. So convincing was the portrayal by the chief protagonists in the Maddock Films' production that the emotions spilled out of the cinema halls into the streets. Especially after Samajwadi Party's Mumbai MLA Abu Asim Azmi put up a defence of Aurangzeb on March 3, saying, "Wrong history is being shown. Aurangzeb built many temples. I do not consider him a cruel ruler. Also, the battle between Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj and Aurangzeb was for state administration, not between Hindus and Muslims." Whatever the results of actual conflicts, in the long view of popular history, Maratha warriors are the clear winners and Aurangzeb a universally reviled figure. Incensed at Abu Azmi's statement, Sangh parivar affiliates such as the Vishva Hindu Parishad and the Bajrang Dal called for the razing of Aurangzeb's grave at Khultabad near Aurangabad (renamed Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar a couple of years ago). They found ready support from the BJP and the Shiv Sena, members of the ruling Mahayuti coalition in the state. Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath weighed in, too, declaring that glorifying 'invaders' was an act of 'treason' that 'new India' would not tolerate. Azmi has been suspended from the Maharashtra legislature for the ongoing budget session.

An uneasy calm returned to Maharashtra after Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis skilfully pleaded helplessness at being unable to disturb Aurangzeb's grave as it was a protected structure under the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI). He did assert, though, that his government will not allow the glorification of the Mughal. "Why do we want the grave of Aurangya (Aurangzeb)?" he asked. "But as you know, the ASI declared it a protected site 50 years ago and hence the state and Union governments are vested with protecting it. It is unfortunate that we are forced to protect the tomb of Aurangya, who had killed thousands of our people."

Meanwhile, rumours of a *chaadar* (sheet) with Quranic inscriptions being burnt during statewide protests against Aurangzeb by Hindu right-wing groups